



Data backs her: Deloitte's '2025 Women@Work' report shows that nearly nine in ten women believe requesting flexibility will hurt their career.

UNSPOKEN MENTAL TOLL

Women's composure at work often hides a mental-health crisis unfolding quietly beneath the surface.

"Women aren't burning out because they're less resilient," says Richa Singh, co-founder of emotional wellness platform YourDOST. "They're burning out because they absorb more of the emotional load at work."

YourDOST's upcoming 'Decade of Wellness' report reveals that 74.68% of women experience high stress, compared to 61.47% of men. Severe burnout is also higher among women (26.71% vs. 23.02%). High anxiety is nearly double that of men (44.34% vs. 27.48%). The burden grows heavier when paired with weaker support systems, as half of all women report low emotional support, according to YourDOST's Emotional Wellbeing of Entrepreneurs (2024).

Higher anxiety and sustained burnout create the perfect conditions for imposter syndrome, threat responses, and chronic overcompensation.

A Deloitte report confirms a hidden crisis: only half of women rate their mental health as good, only four in ten can disconnect from work, and nearly 90% fear their manager would judge them for disclosing challenges.

CAREGIVING CRUNCH

Caregiving remains one of the most persistent and least addressed barriers to women's workforce participation as women often face the double burden of unpaid domestic work.

Numbers elucidate this problem. As per the Deloitte report, one in 20 women say the lack of reliable care could force them to quit their jobs. The report estimates that the care gap leads to over two million lost workdays each year, translating into \$16.5 billion in missed economic opportunity. And the anxieties aren't limited to current caregivers: one in three women fear that the absence of a strong care infrastructure could slow or derail their careers in the coming years.

Women re-entering the workforce after maternity breaks face the steepest uphill climb; only 3% feel they have progressed in their careers after returning.

Karishma Parikh, Vice President—HR at workforce solutions provider Adecco India, sums up the struggle: "Managing childcare alongside a demanding career is something I continue to navigate even today."

This is where supportive ecosystems transform futures. Arti Dua, Partner and CHRO, EY India, recalls being hesitant when she was offered the Partner role. "My kids were young, and I worried constantly. My leaders told me to work at a pace that suited me and supported me through the transition."

To-Do List For Companies



Normalise flexibility without penalty—make hybrid/remote gender-neutral and free of ambition bias



Create reliable caregiving infrastructure—crèches, backup childcare, elder-care and emergency support



Strengthen psychological safety—train managers to recognise emotional load, burnout, and anxiety



Support women's health needs openly—menstrual leave, IVF support, menopause policies, and trained managers



Offer targeted mid-career upskilling, especially in digital and AI skills, to prevent the mid-career break



Implement transparent, audited pay structures—regular pay audits and clear compensation frameworks



Build strong sponsorship pathways—leaders advocating for women, not just mentoring them